Zlata's Diary

By Zlata Filipovic

INTRODUCTION

In April 6, 1992 the siege of Sarajevo began. It was the longest siege of a capital city in modern history and produced the worst atrocities in Europe since World War II. Over the course of 3 ½ years, 100,000 people were killed, and half of Bosnia's population of 4.4 million fled their homes. Zlata Filipovic's family stayed.

Zlata Filipovic, now in her early 30s and living in Paris, was a pre-teen in Sarajevo during the Bosnian war. Her diary of life under siege touched the world. In a recent interview Ms Filipovic says her dreams of peace for Bosnia are still the same . . . and that even today, young people still want to escape Sarajevo. "I really worry that violence is going to erupt again," she said. "There is still so much ethnic hatred and resentment. The majority of my friends are leaving or have already left. There is no work, no hope, and no future there."

This is Zlata's Diary by Zlata Filipovic

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Thursday, March 5, 1992

Oh, God! Things are heating up in Sarajevo. On Sunday (March 1) a small group of armed civilians (as they say on TV) killed a Serbian wedding guest and wounded the priest. On March 2 (Monday) the whole city was full of barricades. At 6:00 people got fed up and went out into the streets. The procession set out from the cathedral. It went past the parliament building and made its way through the entire city. Several people were wounded at the Marshal Tito army barracks. People sang: *(The following is added from Stanza 2 of The National Anthem of Bosnia from 1992 – 1998 – see the You Tube Link at the end of this selection for the melody)*

Bosnian	English Translation
Jedna si, jedina,	You are the one and only
moja domovina.	The only homeland I have
Jedna si jedina	You are the one and only
Bosna i Hercegovina.	Bosnia and Herzegovina

and cried "Bosnia, Bosnia," "Sarajevo, Sarajevo," "We'll live together" and "Come outside." Zdravko Grebo said on the radio that history was in the making.

The next day everything was the same as before. Classes, music, school . . . But in the evening, the news came that 3,000 Chetniks [Serbian nationalists] were coming from Pale to attack Sarajevo.

On March 4 (Wednesday) the barricades were removed, the "kids" [a popular term for politicians] had come to some agreement. Great?! [But later] that day our art teacher told us to go home. Something was wrong again! There was a panic. The girls started screaming and the boys quietly blinked their eyes. Daddy came home from work early that day too. It's all too much!

Tuesday, May 5, 1992

The shooting seems to be dying down. I guess they've caused enough misery, although I don't know why. It has something to do with politics. I just hope the "kids" come to some agreement. Oh, if only they would, so we could live and breathe as humans again. The things that have happened here these past few days are terrible. I want it to stop forever. PEACE! PEACE!

We've rearranged things in the apartment. My room and Mommy and Daddy's are too dangerous to be in.

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They face the hills, which is where they're shooting from. If only you knew how scared I am to go near the windows. So, we turned a safe corner of the sitting room into a "bedroom." We sleep on mattresses on the floor. It's strange and awful. But, it's safer that way.

Thursday, May 7, 1992

I was almost positive the war would stop, but today . . . Today a shell fell on the park in front of my house, the park where I used to play and sit with my girlfriends. A lot of people were hurt. Dado, Jaca and her mother have come home from the hospital, Selma lost a kidney but she's still in the hospital. AND NINA IS DEAD. A piece of shrapnel lodged in her brain and she died. She was such a sweet, nice little girl. We used to play together in the park. Is it possible I'll never see Nina again? Nina, an innocent eleven-year-old little girl–the victim of a stupid war. I feel sad. I cry and wonder why? She didn't do anything. A disgusting war has destroyed a young child's life. Nina, I'll always remember you as a wonderful little girl.

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Wednesday, May 27, 1992

SLAUGHTER! MASSACRE! HORROR! CRIME! BLOOD! SCREAMS! TEARS! DESPAIR!

That's what Vaso Miskin Street looks like today. Two shells exploded in the street and one in the market. Mommy was nearby at the time. She ran to Grandma and Granddad's. Daddy and I were beside ourselves because she hadn't come home. I saw some of it on TV but I still can't believe what I actually saw. It's unbelievable. I've got a lump in my throat and a knot in my tummy. HORRIBLE. They're taking the wounded to the hospital. It's a madhouse. We kept going to the window hoping to see Mommy. We didn't know what had happed to her. Was she alive? At 4:00, Daddy decided to go and check the hospital. I looked out the window one more time and. . . I SAW MOMMY RUNNING ACROSS THE BRIDGE. As she came into the house she started shaking and crying. Through her tears she told us how she had seen dismembered bodies. All the neighbors came because they had been afraid for her. Thank God, Mommy is with us. Thank God. A HORRIBLE DAY. UNFORGETTABLE. HORRIBLE! HORRIBLE! I don't know how often I've written

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that word. HORRIBLE. We've had too much horror. The days here are full of horror. Maybe we in Sarajevo could rename the day and call it horror, because that's really what it's like.

Monday, June 29, 1992

BOREDOM!!! SHOOTING!!! SHELLING!!! PEOPLE BEING KILLED!!! DESPAIR!!! HUNGER!!! MISERY!!! FEAR!!!

That's my life! The life of an innocent eleven-year-old schoolgirl!! A schoolgirl without a school, without the fun and excitement of school. A child without games, without friends, without the sun, without birds, without nature, without fruit, without chocolate or sweets, with just a little powdered milk. In short, a child without a childhood. A wartime child. I now realize that I am really living through a war, I am witnessing an ugly, disgusting war. I and thousands of other children in this town that is being destroyed, that is crying, weeping, seeking help, but getting none. God, will this ever stop, will I ever be a schoolgirl again, will I ever enjoy my childhood again? I once heard that childhood is the most wonderful time of

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your life. And it is. I loved it, and now an ugly war is taking it all away from me. Why? I feel sad. I feel like crying. I am crying.

Thursday, November 19, 1992

Nothing new on the political front. They are adopting some resolutions, the "kids" are negotiating, and we are dying, freezing, starving, crying, parting with our friends, leaving our loved ones.

I keep wanting to explain these stupid politics to myself, because it seems to me that politics caused this war, making it our everyday reality. It looks to me as though these politics mean Serbs, Croats and Muslims. But they are all people. They are all the same. They all look like people, there's no difference. They all have arms, legs and heads, they walk and talk, but now there's "something" that wants to make them different.

Among my girlfriends, among our friends, in our family, there are Serbs and Croats and Muslims. It's a mixed group and I never knew who was a Serb, a Croat or a Muslim. Now politics has started meddling around. It has put an "S" on Serbs, and "M" on Muslims and a "C" on

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Croats, it wants to separate them. And to do so it has chosen the worst, blackest pencil of all – the pencil of war which spells only misery and death.

Of course, I'm "young," and politics are conducted by "grown-up." But I think we "young" would do it better. We certainly wouldn't have chosen war.

Friday, July 23, 1993

Ever since July 17, various people have been coming around – journalists, reporters, cameramen. From Spain, France, the US, England . . . and yesterday a crew came from ABC News. They filmed me for American TV as the "person of the week." Hey, imagine, me a personality?

They filmed me in my room, by my piano, in my apartment with my parents. They talked to me. In English, of course. I have to boast and tell you that they told me my English is EXCELLENT.

And tonight the world will be looking at me. Meanwhile I'm looking at the candle, and all around me is darkness. I'm looking in the dark.

Can that outside world see the darkness I see? Just as I can't see myself on TV tonight, so the rest of the world

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probably can't see the darkness I'm looking at. We're at two ends of the world. Our lives are so different. Theirs is a bright light. Ours is darkness.

Friday, September 17, 1993

The "kids" are negotiating something, signing something. Again giving us hope that this madness will end. There's supposed to be a cease-fire tomorrow and on September 21 at Sarajevo airport everybody is supposed to sign FOR PEACE. Will the war stop on the day that marks the change from one season to another???

With all the disappointments I've had with previous truces and signatures, I can't believe it.

I can't believe it because another horrible shell fell today, ending the life of a three-year-old little boy, wounding his sister and mother.

All I know is that the result of their little games is 15,000 dead in Sarajevo, 3,000 of them children, 50,000 permanent invalids, whom I already see in the streets on crutches, in wheelchairs, armless and legless. And I know that there's no room left in the cemeteries and parks to bury the latest victims.

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Maybe that's why this madness should stop.

Sunday, October 17, 1993

Yesterday our friends in the hills reminded us of their presence and that they are now in control and can kill, wound, destroy . . . yesterday was a truly horrible day.

Five hundred and ninety shells. From 4:30 in the morning on, throughout the day. Six dead and fifty-six wounded. That is yesterday's toll.

AGAIN! Again and again they keep sinking all our boats, taking and burning all our hopes. People said that they wouldn't do it anymore. That there would soon be an end to it, that everything would resolve itself. THAT THIS STUPID WAR WOULD END!

Oh God, why do they spoil everything? Sometimes I think it would be better if they kept shooting, so that we wouldn't find it so hard when it starts up again. This way, just as you relax, it starts up AGAIN. I am convinced now that it will never end. Because some people don't want it to, some evil people who hate children and ordinary folk.

I keep thinking that we're alone in this hell, that nobody is thinking of us, nobody is offering us a helping

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hand. [No] . . . People worry about us, they think about us, but as sub-humans. They want to destroy us. Why? I keep asking myself why?

We haven't done anything. We're innocent. But helpless! . . . some evil people hate children and ordinary folk.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier

The National Anthem of Bosnia from 1992 – 1998 can be listened to at the following link
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NiEd4dFVKn4

A sample of a teen speaking English with a Bosnian accent can be listened to at the following link:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LfgiAR63pCc

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